Pandya, Keralaputra and Satiyaputra. Note the longevity of the names. The Cholas would remain a powerful clan for the next one and half millennia and would head a powerful empire of their own in the tenth and eleventh century AD. We will revisit them in a later chapter. The name of the Keralaputras has proven even more persistent, and the state at the south-western tip of the Indian peninsula is today called Kerala in their memory.

OF IMPERIAL PILLARS AND EDICTS

Ashoka is the first Indian monarch who has left us artifacts that indisputably belong to his reign. To be absolutely accurate, the name Ashoka does not appear on any major edict inscription. The edicts were issued by a king who called himself ‘Beloved of the Gods’, Piyadassi. However, there is strong circumstantial evidence that link Piyadassi to Buddhist legends about a great king called Ashoka. The link was discovered from dynastic lists in the Puranas, Hindu religious texts, that describe a king called Ashoka as Chandragupta’s grandson.

Best known of Ashokan artifacts are a series of edicts engraved on rocks and on stone pillars scattered across the empire. These pillars and inscriptions have been found across the subcontinent from Afghanistan in the north to Karnataka in the south, Gujarat in the west to Bengal in the east. They are also scattered across the northern plains, including one in Delhi (near Greater Kailash). Given the lapse of time, it is safe to assume that there were many more pillars and inscriptions that did not survive. Still, what remains is impressive and gives us a sense of the scale and extent of the Mauryan empire.

The edicts and inscriptions have elicited a great deal of interest ever since they were deciphered in the nineteenth century. This is not surprising given their age as well as the sentiments they express. Ashoka openly regrets the invasion of Kalinga and the bloodshed it caused. He exhorts his subjects to be good citizens, while underscoring his own commitment to their welfare. Below is an example of one of his edicts: